

BOYS BASKETBALL

Aggressive, balanced Rangers turn back Wildcats

EDDIE DWYER
Plain Dealer Reporter#9 LAKEWOOD 75
#5 ST. IGNATIUS 70

Lakewood's John Dillingham said it was a game of persistent effort, that he and his teammates couldn't let up, "not for a second."

The Rangers, hustling from the opening tip until the final buzzer, turned back St. Ignatius, 75-70, last night in a nonleague boys basketball game at Lakewood.

Using an aggressive half-court defense and getting balanced

scoring, the Rangers improved to 7-1. St. Ignatius, which got a game-high 32 points from senior guard Terry Walsh, slipped to 4-3.

"A 110 percent effort on defense, we know that's the key to our success," Dillingham said after Lakewood defeated the Wildcats for the second consecutive season. "That and making our free throws and our open shots, and pounding the ball in-

side to our big men."

For most of the first 16 minutes, the Rangers did all of the above.

With Dillingham holding the hot hand from the perimeter and reserves Antonio Kidd and Verdel Billingsley providing solid minutes, Lakewood moved to a 40-30 lead at halftime.

A 6-4 senior forward, Dillingham made three of the Rangers' six 3-pointers in the first half and finished with a team-high 19 points.

"Everything [St. Ignatius]

does, for the most part, stems from its ability to reverse the ball," said Lakewood coach Rob Stone. "And I thought we did a real nice job of rotating on defense and keeping the ball on one side. I just kept telling our kids not to let up. We knew they were going to make their runs, and, for the most part, we responded pretty well when they did."

Sparked by five quick points by Walsh, St. Ignatius went on a 10-2 run and closed to 42-40 on a 3-pointer by junior guard Matt Porath with 5:59 remaining in

the third quarter.

But Lakewood responded with a basket by Dillingham and a breakaway, two-handed slam-dunk by senior post Mark Fannin. After strong moves down low by Fannin and senior forward Robbie Butts, the Rangers led, 52-41, with 2:16 left in the third quarter. Fannin finished with 16 points.

St. Ignatius made a couple of late runs, closing to 64-60 on a spinning one-hander along the baseline by Walsh with 2:23 left, and to 73-70 on a 3-pointer by

Walsh with 4.1 seconds left.

But Lakewood sealed the victory behind the clutch free-throw shooting of Kidd and Fannin. Kidd, a junior point guard, finished with 13 points.

"Their half-court pressure sort of took us out of synch," said Wildcats coach Brian Becker. "Dillingham stepped up early and hit a couple of big 3-balls for them, and I thought Kidd played a real nice floor game."

To reach this Plain Dealer reporter: edwyer@plained.com, 216-999-4677

GIRLS HOLIDAY CAGE CLASSIC



C.H. PETECOPELAND / THE PLAIN DEALER

Zyrice Mitchell is hemmed in by Mentor defenders during Regina's 60-46 victory in the Holiday Cage Classic at Cleveland State.

Regina pulls away

Well-traveled Royals have enough to hold off Cardinals

CARL MATZELLE
Plain Dealer Reporter

If a well-balanced diet is the key to a healthy lifestyle, then the Regina Royals are in superb physical condition.

The Royals combined excellent offense and defense and improved to 9-0 with a 60-46 win over Mentor last night in the Holiday Cage Classic at Cleveland State's Woodling Gym.

It was the 106th win for Pat Diulus as Regina's coach and 497th victory overall.

The Lady Cardinals, whose last victory was against Admiral King two weeks ago, were anything but rusty. It wasn't really an advantage for the Royals, either, who flew home New Year's Eve from San Diego after winning the Surf-n-Slam Hoops Classic.

"I'm still recovering from jet-lag," said Diulus. "I can only imagine how my team feels."

Regina senior forward Siedah Williams left the game early in

the second quarter with three fouls and two points, but the Royals managed to pull ahead, 28-23, at the half, thanks to hot shooting by junior guard Simone Redd (eight points) and sophomore forward Zyrice Mitchell (eight points, five rebounds).

"I was a little tired," said Williams. "Mentor kept me out of rhythm in the first half, but coach Diulus told me to forget about it and finish strong in the second half."

Williams did just that, scoring eight points, six in the fourth quarter, to help Regina pull away from a Mentor team that refused to quit.

Mentor sophomore center Megan Skouby led the Cardinals with 15 points and 14 rebounds.

"We practiced hard and scrimmaged during the layoff, so we were ready to play," said Skouby. "I just have to work harder at stepping up earlier in the game."

Mentor hung around despite Royals runs of 14-0 in the sec-

ond quarter and 9-0 in the fourth.

"I'm disappointed that we lost," said Mentor coach Mark Chicone. "We made a game of it and pushed Regina around, but we need to execute better. I didn't come down here to lose, and my players have to learn that it isn't good enough to just show up and play."

Royals junior guard Simone Redd, who finished with 17 points and hit the only 3-pointer of the game, said the team definitely suffered the aftereffects of its tournament win against Philadelphia's Archbishop Wood in San Diego.

"We had some leftover jet-lag," said Redd. "The time difference, combined with hard practices took their toll. We were lucky to put Mentor away in the fourth quarter. They're a very good team."

"We played like we were tired," said Diulus. "We didn't attack well in the first half, but we made some adjustments,

double-teaming them and executing better to win."

Xenia 50, Archbishop Hoban 38 Buccaneers junior forward Ashley Brown scored 18 of her 27 points in the first half and Xenia led at halftime, 30-18. The Knights drew within 35-31 in the third quarter, but they couldn't capitalize on numerous free throws.

Copley 61, Dunbar 56 Indians junior guard Jenny Markle hit six 3-point shots and scored 27 points. Copley led, 34-33, at halftime thanks to sophomore Melanie Small's 3-point shot at the buzzer. Dunbar had a chance to tie the game late in the fourth quarter, but senior center Meloni Benson, who had just hit a 3-point shot, missed from the 3-point line with 1.4 seconds left.

To reach this Plain Dealer reporter: cmatzelle@plained.com, 216-999-4748

GIRLS BASKETBALL

Hurricanes storm past Longhorns

BOB FORTUNA
Plain Dealer Reporter#25 BROOKLYN 65
#23 LUTHERAN WEST 37

Stunning.

It's the only way to explain Brooklyn's dominance of defending MAC-8 Conference champion Lutheran West last night in a 65-37 MAC-8 girls basketball victory.

What's even more impressive is the unbeaten Hurricanes (10-0, 7-0) did it on the Longhorns' court to take sole possession of first place in the conference.

"Their substitutes shot well, too," Lutheran West coach Karen Wittrock said. "Our turnovers dug us deep, and then we had to come back, and we're not used to being behind."

An aggressive, man-for-man defense forced Lutheran West into 12 first-half turnovers that Brooklyn converted into 11 points and a 27-16 lead at halftime.

Brooklyn struck for six straight points midway through the first quarter, then added a 7-0 run two minutes later.

"There's never a comfort zone against [Lutheran West]," Hurricanes coach Jim Verba said. "We told the girls [at halftime] they just had to keep it going."

And keep it going they did.

Unlike the first half, Brooklyn did its second-half damage from the field, making 52 percent of its shots, including a 10-of-15 effort in the fourth quarter. The Hurricanes sank eight of their first 10 shots in the quarter.

"I've scouted them before, and they shot like 50 percent, and that's much better than we shoot," Wittrock said. "This Brooklyn team, a lot of those kids have been playing together for a long time, and they've got some shooters."

Jessica Latimer's 24 points and 10 rebounds led Brooklyn. Dana Dempsey finished with 16 points, and Sarah Douglass had 15. The Longhorns (9-1, 6-1) had one player in double figures with Andra Boriska scoring 10 points.

"This victory means so much," Dempsey said. "We've been waiting for this for a long time. This has been our passion. We've been working hard every day, getting ready for them because we want to win the MAC-8."

"We were afraid that maybe their size would shut us down, but obviously, it didn't. We're quicker than them, and our defense spread like wildfire. Just because we're small doesn't mean we're not as strong."

The taller Longhorns held a slim 25-23 edge in rebounds.

"The girls didn't have any lapses, offensively, and they kept the defensive pressure up," Verba said. "We got out to an early lead, and we were able to keep the momentum."

To reach this Plain Dealer reporter: bfortuna@plained.com, 216-999-4479

WRESTLING

Year-round work pays for Cardinals

PAT GALBINCEA
Plain Dealer Reporter

Southview wrestling coach Dan Ternes has been around long enough to know good wrestling from great wrestling.

That, unfortunately for Saints fans, was the dilemma yesterday in a triangular meet at Mentor. The host Cardinals entered with a 2-0 dual-meet record and a tournament victory at the Solon Comet Classic. Southview also was 2-0 and a tournament winner at the Riverside Rumble. Similar records, indeed, but the Cardinals easily won the head-to-head confrontation, 55-12, and also whipped Euclid, 76 to minus-1. Southview defeated Euclid, 57-23.

Ternes, who founded the Saints wrestling program in 1969, did not like the matchup with Mentor before the meet.

"We're a good young team with decent upperweights," Ternes said. "But Mentor is solid everywhere with very good upperweights. If you've got any weaknesses, Mentor will expose them."

"We have one wrestler — [state qualifier] Dan Mitcheff — who wrestles all year. That fact alone showed the difference, although some of our kids told me they will start wrestling in the summer."

Cardinals coach Ken Skilton said there's a simple reason Mentor again has become tough in dual meets and tournaments.

"We have a core of kids who are wrestling all year," Skilton said. "This sport has gotten so tough you can't expect to go to the next level just wrestling between November and March. We also have 55 kids in our room. That provides good practices."

Skilton's point was proven in the 160-pound bout between seniors Dexter Hough-Snee of Mentor and Jamar Miller of Southview, who had a 13-7 record. The powerful Miller shot in on the more-experienced Hough-Snee, who applied a quarter-nelson on Miller's head and spun behind him for a takedown. That was one of several "surgical" moves Hough-Snee made in an 11-1 win.

Cardinals Nate Hough-Snee (189) and Paul Burger (215) had pins, as did lighter teammates Matt Lerer (103), Dan Lastoria (119), A.J. Carl (135) and Payton O'Bryan (152). Sean Cybulski, a state qualifier at heavyweight, edged taller Joe Wilson (17-5), 3-2, by pummeling his way into a penalty point called on Wilson for stalling.

Mitcheff, at 112, pinned Jake Distler in a half-nelson at 3:39.

Euclid, 5-3 entering the triangular meet, had five wrestlers yesterday. Junior state qualifier Steve Dominick (189) has been ill and is not expected back until next weekend.

"Between illnesses, injuries, family deaths, and wrestlers who just decided to take vacations, we were decimated," said Panthers coach Joe Tucceri, the last Euclid wrestler to place at state (1997).

Euclid (5-5) won four of its five matches against Southview, including a 152-pound bout in which Saints sophomore Darek Harvey had a 5-0 lead on Scott Sattler, who then rolled through Harvey's half-nelson to get a fall in 1:39 — only to injure his collarbone.

To reach this Plain Dealer reporter: pgalbincea@plained.com, 216-999-4677

ROUNDUP

Griffin sparks Glenville over Toledo Libbey

From staff reports

James "Woo" Griffin did it all for Glenville last night against Toledo Libbey.

The senior scored 29 points — including five 3-pointers and a few dunks — to lead the Tarblooders to a 76-67 home win last night in a nonleague boys basketball game.

Glenville, ranked 13th in The Plain Dealer Top 25, also got 16 points from Emery Williams. The Tarblooders will play at No. 24 Bedford on Tuesday night.

Olmsted Falls 75, N. Olmsted 45 The Bulldogs, trailing by two points after the first quarter, held the Eagles to six points

in the second quarter and went on to hand North Olmsted its first Southwestern Conference loss.

Olmsted Falls, ranked seventh by The Plain Dealer, had three players in double figures: Steve Gansey with 21 points, Tim Curran with 17 and Jamar Scales with 15.

The Bulldogs are 8-0, 4-0. North Olmsted is 6-2, 3-1.

Brush 59, VASJ 52 Junior Steve Carter scored 14 points in the third quarter and helped the 10th-ranked Arcs (8-1) earn a nonleague win at home.

Carter finished with 22 points. Teammate Marcel Frost, who had two fouls in the first two minutes of the game, finished

with 14. Villa Angela-St. Joseph (4-5) got 10 points from Davel Lighty. The Vikings held a 14-6 lead after the first quarter.

N. Royalton 77, Berea 62 Julian Guilfoyle scored 27 points and teammate Mark Friscone had 21 as the Bears pulled away for a Pioneer Conference win. North Royalton is ranked 15th by The Plain Dealer. Sean Nieman had a team-high 21 points for Berea.

Brunswick 53, Medina 41 The Blue Devils, 18th in The Plain Dealer Top 25, had four players score in double figures as they earned a Pioneer Conference road victory. Brunswick is 8-1.

Girls basketball Padua 53, Trinity 45 Jen Nagy, a 6-2 forward, led all scorers with 17 points as the Bruins stayed unbeaten in the North Coast League with a road victory.

Padua (7-2, 5-0) also got 15 points from Stefani Jaworski. The Bruins are ranked 13th by The Plain Dealer. Trinity is 6-3, 3-2 and ranked 21st.

Beachwood 38, Cuyahoga Hts. 36 Selena Budge sank a layup with eight seconds left to give the host Bison a win in a Metropolitan Area Conference-8 game. Budge finished with 17 points. Teammate Jacqui Goas scored 10, and Allison Aarons grabbed 16 rebounds.